Dorian sat in his home office waiting for the timer to tick down to zero. It was nearly time for this… System, whatever it was, to come online. He had awoken early, eaten breakfast, and poured himself a strong tea. The steam lifting off and filled the air with the minty aroma. 3… 2… 1…

Then the messages filled his vision, not the simple alert that initially showed up on his omnipad. Way too lucid and precise to be a hallucination. Maybe this would be his way to finally move forward in life. To be more than just a second hand assistant to Mayor Duncan.

The Mayor had an opportunity he was wasting, one to embrace the old ways of the UE and remove many of the undesirables. But he wasted that trying to “be fair to all”, even those who didn’t truly deserve it. He had good friends who were not considered important enough to be given a seat on a ship yet. One’s who he felt made the entire economy of Silvercreek flow.

Dorian pushed his contemplations aside and just as he started to read all the data floating before him a figure appeared startling the middle aged rotund man. He tried to move, to do something but fear had taken him. All he could accomplish was to minimize the System’s screens before him to see his fate stare back at him.

The glowing surreal figure walks over to a bookshelf and picks up an action figure between two fingers, carefully, as if it carried some sort of otherworldly taint.

“These are your Gods now? Pathetic,” it intones, and drops the figure back into place, now toppled instead of standing proudly, as though it had failed some invisible test of reverence.

“No, that’s just an action figure,” Dorian says, though unease threaded his voice. And valuable he thought, nobody even manufactures them anymore.

“You pay homage to it. You speak of these 'characters' in stories often. You act as if they have some basis for your own morality. You sit in worship for hours, you call it bingeing, I believe. You toss your coin at them, hoping they continue their fake morality. You spread the gospel of these *plastic* figures in hopes of finding others of similar mind. It is a god. A false one. A mere petroleum-based idol.”

“Well, it’s not all that serious,” Dorian mutters, trying to shrug it off.

The figure doesn’t waver. “These characters you worship go out and kill the ‘Evil Gods.’ Kratos is a popular one, I believe. A mere mortal who uplifted themselves and marched off to stab gods with a sharpened iron stick.” Dorian opened his mouth but the figure lifted a hand silencing him. “Shut up, I do not need correction. The idea remains. You know nothing of the divine realm or any other. Even in your make-believe fallacies, you fail to grasp its concepts. These are mortal fantasies, attempts at your lives have meaning beyond being basic nutrition. For something more eternal when you finally pass, first in body, then in memory, forever. You know nothing. You comprehend nothing. You are nothing. But perhaps I can show you… a taste, a teaser, if you will.”

The light around the figure tightens, not brighter, denser, as if reality itself were being folded and compressed.

The room creaks, not the walls, but *the idea of a room*. The bookshelf blurs, the spines of the comics smearing into glyphs that briefly resemble ribs and tablets etched into bone. The fallen action figure twitches once, plastic groaning as if it wanted to be metal or flesh.

Dorian swallows. “Okay,” he says, his human reflex defaulting to politeness in the face of incomprehensibility. “I’m guessing this is the part where the floor opens?”

The figure does not laugh. Laughter is a mortal luxury. It extends one finger and presses it gently against Dorian’s forehead.

The world falls inward.

For a fraction of a second, no, that word is wrong, time is unraveling, Dorian exists as a diagram. Nerves like glowing wires. Thoughts stacked like translucent cards. Every memory tagged, indexed, weighed. He extended his nodes outward. He didn’t have appendages anymore, just further extensions, more diagrams, more… him.

Then the taste begins.

He sees processions: civilizations marching in perfect faith toward entities that never learned their names. Prayer engines burning belief like furnaces burn coal. Suns grew and dimmed not by entropy, but by *attention*.

He feels scale: pretend gods that are not people, not minds, but forces with preferences. Hunger given flesh. Gravity with opinions. Divinity that does not rule, it consumed.

Dorian screams, but it comes out as a static hiss of colors and ideas, his mouth busy remembering how language works.

The finger withdraws. Reality snaps back like an abused elastic band stretched dangerously thin. He collapses into a chair that is once again a chair, gasping, sweating, alive in the aggressively boring way only humans get to be.

The glowing figure watches him, patiently, the way a biologist watches a mayfly finish its entire life in a petri dish.

“That,” it says calmly, “was *nothing*. A courtesy. A preview.”

Dorian wipes his face with shaking hands. His laugh comes out cracked, half-hysterical. “Cool. Coolcoolcool. So… still not worship?”

The figure tilts its head, genuinely curious.

“You mistake the point,” it says. “Your idols are not offensive because they are false. They are offensive because they are *aspirational*.”

It gestures to the comics, now fully mundane again. Ink. Paper. Escapism.

“You imagine mortals who *matter*. Who strike upward and are not erased. Who defy the chain of existence and leave scars.”

A pause.

“That idea,” the figure admits, almost reluctantly, “is… dangerous.”

Dorian looks at the fallen action figure and takes reign over his fear allowing him to move again. He reaches out, sets it upright again. Not proudly. Just… deliberately.

“Yeah,” he says quietly. “That’s kind of the point.” Dorian is still breathing too hard from the aftertaste of infinity pressing against his skull.

“You have no actual perception of anything,” the figure continues, pacing slowly now. Each step is subtly wrong, as if it were walking through slightly different versions of the room at once. “Not scale. No consequence. Even the most basic aspects of the universe.”

It gestures around the room. The walls shimmer, briefly revealing layers beneath them, overlapping spaces, misaligned angles, places that do not exist all at once.

“Movement,” it says. “Not through space. Through *this* sliver of reality itself.”

Dorian feels it then. A sensation he doesn’t have language for. Like standing still while the world subtly rotates around him. Like the room is waiting for him to take a step it hasn’t taught him how to take.

The figure straightens.

“I can teach you,” it says casually, as if offering a hobby. “I can draw it up from within you.”

Dorian looks at the shelf. At the figures. The stories. Mortals who dared to matter.

His voice is hoarse when he finally speaks. “And what do you get out of it?”

“Service,” it says. “Perspective. A mind willing to look where others refuse.”

A beat.

“And eventually,” it adds, almost kindly, “a hand capable of reaching where mine is limited.”

The room settles. The shelves stop whispering at him. The reality pretends it was never threatened.

Dorian exhales slowly, grounding himself in the mundane. The chair beneath him. The air in his lungs. The stubborn fact that he is still *here*. Dorian desperately sifted through his thoughts to defend himself here, to find flaws, to latch onto any life boat drifting by.

“Look,” he says, rubbing his face, “I’m not really religious. I try to be a good person. Far as I’m concerned, that’s all I need to avoid going to hell. If it even exists.”

The glowing figure turns toward him, not sharply, not angrily. With the patience of something that has heard this exact sentence spoken in ten thousand dead languages.

“Ah. *Hell*,” it says. There is something almost fond in the word. Like nostalgia.

“I have read your idolatry’s version of it. Endless fire. Endless screaming. Pain without purpose, repetition without evolution.” A faint pulse of light ripples across its form. “What a novel and utterly useless concept.”

It drifts closer, the room subtly bending to accommodate its presence.

“You have no idea what awaits you,” it continues calmly. “And you have no idea what hell actually is.”

Dorian opens his mouth, then hesitates. Something in the air feels… thinner. Like the margin for interruption has narrowed.

“It is not physical torture,” the figure says. “I assure you of that. Physicality is merely a limitation of this level of reality. Crude. Inefficient. Barely worth engaging when dealing with something as persistent as a soul.”

It raises one hand, palm open.

“Pain is a teacher, but a blunt one. It overwhelms. It distracts. Souls break too quickly under it, dissolve into noise.”

The hand closes slowly into a fist.

“True punishment is *clarity*.”

Dorian’s stomach tightens.

“Hell,” the figure says, “is perfect awareness without agency. Memory without motion. Want without reach.”

The room doesn’t darken as much as the concept of light is removed. As if certain possibilities have quietly been taken out of the equation that bound reality together.

“It is being forced to observe every version of yourself you could have been,” it continues, voice steady, precise, “while forever remaining the one you chose to become.”

Images flicker at the edge of Dorian’s perception. Not visions, *implications*. Roads not taken. Words not spoken. People who might have lived. He was mayor, he was a beggar, he had a wife, he was alone again, he had a child, the child lived, the child died, then the reality that was not… collapsed leaving Dorian panting.

“It is time without progress,” the figure says softly. “Existence without impact. An eternity measured not in screams… but in the overwhelming density of *regret.*”

Dorian swallows. “That’s… that’s just psychology.”

The glow brightens slightly.

“Psychology,” it repeats, amused, “a failed attempt at the mortal study of shadows cast by higher-order mechanics. Often tainted by their own plastic morality.”

A pause.

“You strive to be a good person,” it says. “Admirable. But goodness without understanding is coincidence. And coincidence does not survive eternity.”

It leans in, close enough now that Dorian can feel a pressure behind his eyes.

“But you,” it says quietly, “are different.”

Dorian looks up despite himself.

“You have already tasted scale. You have already felt the insult of insignificance.” The glow tightens, becoming almost surgical. “And still, you resist kneeling.”

A beat.

“That is why hell would be such a waste on you.”

Silence stretches.

“And what,” Dorian asks carefully, “are you offering instead?”

The figure smiles. Not kindly.

“Relevance,” it says. “Continuity. The privilege of *choosing* who you become, rather than discovering it too late.” It straightens, the room easing its grip on unreality.

“Ours is a battle of principalities and powers,” the entity says, and for the first time its voice carries something like structure; hierarchy, territory, claim. “And I have a good feeling about you.”

It circles Dorian slowly now. Not predatory. Appraising. Like a general walking the line before choosing officers.

“I would love to recruit you into my principality,” it continues. “Into *my* power.”

The glow dims just enough to feel intimate.

“Mortal coils are fragile things, though. Ephemeral. Poor vessels for what I require. You will need to start small.”

It stops directly in front of him.

“So,” it asks pleasantly, “what say you?”

The room seems to hold its breath.

“The damnation fate of eternal regret,” the entity continues, “or you take control of your own fate… and cut your strings.”

Dorian’s heart is pounding now. Not fear alone, something worse. Recognition. The sense that this question has always been waiting for him, long before tonight.

“What… What do I do?” he asks.

The answer comes immediately. “Open your system interface.”

The words *hook* into his perception. Not spoken. Executed. Reality hiccups. A familiar sensation blooms behind his eyes, the System. Clean. Clinical. Comfortingly indifferent.

And there it is.

A new option, glowing faintly at the edge of his awareness.

[New Combat Class Available]
`[Knife of the Elder Daemon]`

Dorian’s breath catches.

“Select it,” the entity says calmly. “You will gain power over others. The ability to take them into your fold. To bind them; ideologically, spiritually, structurally.”

The glow sharpens.

“The more you take,” it adds, “the stronger you become.”

A pause. Not for drama. For certainty.

“I advise you to secure a position of power as soon as possible. There is an attack coming.”

Something *moves* in the distance of his awareness, future pressure, converging vectors. Silvercreek, suddenly fragile. Exposed.

“If you cannot find opportunity in that,” the entity continues, voice flattening, “to secure your control over this tiny speck of a town… then I have no use for you.”

The room feels smaller now. Or maybe Dorian feels larger.

“Succeed,” it says, “or begin your journey to discover the true nature of hell.”

The System waits.

The class selection pulses once.

“There is no third option.”

Dorian stares at the interface. He thinks of the figures on the shelf. Mortals who mattered. People who seized meaning instead of begging for it. He thinks of Silvercreek. Small. Vulnerable. Easy to protect… if someone strong enough is willing to get their hands dirty.

And finally, he thinks, not of hell but of *irrelevance*.

His hand trembles as he reaches out. Then steadies.

[Class Selected: `Knife of the Elder Daemon`**]**

Somewhere far beyond perception, something vast and patient smiles, not in triumph, but in investment. And in Silvercreek, a future quietly changes course. Not because a god descended.

But because a man decided he would never be small again.